Our Children (3)

As They Begin to Be Rational

Rev Ian Arnold

In my two previous talks on Children, I especially emphasised parental attitudes to the upbringing of their children and what these should be. The Bible, or Word of the Lord, is by no means without guidelines to help us here. Though perhaps we don't often relate them to this particular aspect of things, certain teachings of the Lord in fact have a great deal to say to us where attitudes towards, and influence over, children are concerned. Gentle rebuke as it is, because of the tendency everywhere to place far too much emphasis on worldly success and renown, we have the Lord asking us, 'What good will it be for someone to gain the whole world, yet forfeit their soul?' Matthew 16, 26.

Indeed what are our children profited if they gain the world, become rich and successful, but in the process lose their humility before the Lord and feeling for spiritual things? And then again, while the Lord is speaking to us here as individuals, He is also speaking to us who are charged with the care of children where He says, 'Do not store up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moths and vermin destroy, and where thieves break in and steal. But store up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where moths and vermin do not destroy, and where thieves do not break in and steal. For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.' Matthew 6:19-21. The inclination we have to guard against that is always there, is to place too much emphasis on equipping our children for life in this world, neglecting the preparation that is required if our children are to live the life of heaven.

The Bible offers us guidelines concerning our approach to our children and where our emphasis with them is going to be. What is remarkable is that the Word of the Lord, understood according to its deeper, spiritual meaning, also enables us to understand particular stages of mental growth and development that our children are going through. And it is one of these stages which I am going to discuss.

In the Book of Genesis, Chapter 16, we are told how Abraham's barren wife Sarai, encouraged him to have a child by her hand maid, Hagar. In due course a boy was conceived of whom it was promised would be 'a wild donkey of a man; his hand will be against everyone and everyone's hand against him, and he will live in hostility towards all his brothers.' Genesis 16:12. Even though she had been barren, Sarai subsequently had a son of her own, Isaac; and Ishmael, Hagar's son, was displaced and cast out. He seems to have been very much as it was promised he would be - a wild donkey of a man. Stubborn, uncooperative, conceited and difficult to control; and Sarah, seeing him mocking Isaac, prevailed on Abraham to send both him and his mother, Hagar, away.

In Swedenborg's Writings we are shown that what is described and dealt with in this story is the birth and development of the rational faculty with a person. Indeed, what is touched upon is one of the most perplexing stages of mental development, as young people begin to insist on the right to think about life for themselves; to question what as children, they have previously been told was so and accepted; and to formulate their own opinions about current issues and causes. The values and beliefs which we thought they had accepted come under scrutiny and are criticised, maybe even rejected. There comes an intense enthusiasm for and often involvement in causes which centre on the disadvantaged and underprivileged. There is often an unwillingness to see a different point of view. Even to accept that one could exist! Wonderfully idealistic as the young can be, yet they think to obtain reform by brusque and unacceptable methods.

The story we referred to in Genesis 16, speaks of the birth of two boys to Abraham, first Ishmael the son of Hagar and then Isaac. There are two rationals or two stages of rationality involved. There is what is called the natural rational and then later, the spiritual rational. When rational powers first begin to be exercised and questions start being asked and opinions formed, it is as when Ishmael was born. Later there is modification. There is a realisation of the need to accommodate oneself and to see another person's point of view. Charity enters into things. And reasoning commences not from one's own opinions, but from an understanding of what the Lord teaches. This is when Isaac is born.

The first or natural rational is Ishmael. The second or spiritual rational is Isaac, a quieter and less pugnacious character. It was not without very good reason that it was promised of Ishmael that he would be a wild donkey of a man, for this is what the first rational is. Uncooperative, stubborn and fiercely head strong as the wild donkey was. This is at the same time, just what those in the stage of the first rational are.

"The person whose rational is of such a character that he is solely in truth - even though it be the truth of faith - and who is not at the same time in the good of charity, is," wrote Swedenborg "altogether of such a character. He is a morose man, will bear nothing, is against all, regards everybody as being in falsity, is ready to rebuke, to chastise and to punish: he has no pity, and does not apply or adapt himself to others and study to bend their minds; for he looks at everything from truth, and at nothing from good." Arcana Caelestia 1949

In most communities, the teenage years are and have always been thought to be the most difficult and troublesome of all. And we can see why. But two vitally important things need to be remembered. In the first place our teenagers and young adults enter upon a stage of mental growth and development which, though it may have undesirable side effects, is according to the Lord's order. The Lord intends that we should all grow up and become individuals in our own right. We must in time come to respond of our own choice and freedom to His purposes for us. Or conversely of ourselves and in freedom, reject them. And in order for this situation to come about there must be a questioning, even for a time rejection. There will be argument, and there will be the intensity and enthusiasm for issues and causes we earlier talked about.

All these things are simply symptomatic of the very necessary stage that our young people must go through. They have to start thinking about life for themselves. Hopefully and in the years beforehand, while they were still so accepting, we will have been wise enough to supply them with sufficient material to think from. (Complete misunderstanding of the situation, which it is, some parents justify their neglect of religious instruction for their children on the grounds that when older the children will decide these things for themselves. However how can a child decide in favour of or against such things as the existence of God and the importance of His teaching in the Bible if he does not know and has never been taught anything about these?

This is the first thing. The stage of the Ishmael rational is normal and is part of the Lord's order where mental growth and development are concerned. There is a purpose which lies behind it all. And though the attitudes assumed at that stage may be unpleasant and we may be surprised by the questioning of previously accepted values and standards, these things do not signify great wickedness.

The second thing to be remembered here is that even though the stage is necessary, it is something which does not last forever. What is necessary is an understanding of what is happening. A realisation that it is normal and the care and skill in handling it.

However knowing that the state will pass does not mean that it is to be regarded only with tolerance and patience. Challenged and questioned by the young, we would do well to review and to reconsider what it is that is being challenged and questioned.

One of the uses of the Ishmael rational "is to jar others loose from deadening traditions." With their fresh and new approach to things the young can cause us to rethink old ways, habits and patterns of thought and going about things. The stage we are talking about can be an extremely valuable one. We would do well to listen to what is being argued for. To consider what is being questioned. To ask ourselves as to the merits of what is being urged and agitated for, even if we afterwards find we cannot accept it or see it.

So often the first rational is met by older people digging their heels in and the idealism which fires young people is ridiculed and scoffed at. On the contrary, and "while not yielding to all the demands of the first rational", we are still to respect it and "to encourage its uncompromising affirmation of ideals, and its love of truth."